# Philosophy of Language

Lecture by Lecture Notes

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# Philosophy of Language — Week 1

Introduction

## 1.1 Natural languages

*Natural languages* are spoken by and used to communicate with people. They can be studied by being broken down into the following 4 components:

**Definition 1.1.**

- *Syntax*: the study of how expressions combine to form grammatical units.
- *Semantics*: the study of linguistic meaning.
- *Pragmatics*: the study of how speakers use language.
- *Phonology*: the study of how sounds combine to form units.

**Note.** Noam Chomsky uses the phrase *infinite use of finite means*, which expresses how finite language units can span an infinite combination of those units.

## 1.2 The use/mention distinction

- If a word is *used*, we are using the word in the sense of either meaning/pragmatics.
- If a word is *mentioned*, we are referring to the word itself.

## 1.3 Object language and meta language

**Definition 1.2.**

- *Object language*: the language being studied.
- *Meta language*: the language used to study the object language.

## 1.4 Key definitions

**Definition 1.3.**

- *Synonymy*: two words are synonymous when they have the same meaning.
- *Ambiguous*: one word has multiple meanings.
  - *Lexical ambiguity*: a sentence is ambiguous because of an ambiguous word.
  - *Structural ambiguity*: a sentence is ambiguous because a word in a sentence can be interpreted using multiple syntactic structures.

- *Antonymy*: two words have two meanings that are, in some respect, opposed to each other.
- *Homonymy*: two words are written and pronounced in the same way but each have distinct meanings.
- *Polysemy*: when two words are ambiguous and their meanings are extremely closely related.

## 1.5 Propositions

**Remark** (This is an assumption)**.**

- A proposition is expressed/conveyed by a particular utterance.
- Propositions are not sentence types.

## 1.6 The type/token distinction

**Definition 1.4.**

- *Token*: a verbalised or written occurrence of a particular expression/sentence.
- *Type*: expression/sentence types are literally different categorisations of tokens.

## 1.7 Truth-conditional semantics

**Definition 1.5.** To know the meaning is to know the truth conditions of a sentence.

## 1.8 The Principle of Compositionality

**Definition 1.6** (Principle of Compositionality)**.** The meaning of a sentence is given by the meaning of its component parts and how they are combined.

Any theory of meaning that conforms to this requires the following (we use metavariables to describe the last two):

- *Vocabulary*: words of the language (words, literally).
- *Syntax*: theory of how vocabulary forms to combine into grammatically acceptable sentences (describing what is a sentence). Closure means recursive language: sentences of the same language combine to form the same language.
- *Semantics*: how the meanings of component parts combine (typically truth value, or describing semantic value).

# Philosophy of Language — Week 2

Frege on Reference and Compositionality

**Gottlob Frege**: defender of logicism. Weird right wing guy. Frege's Puzzle.

## 2.1 Frege's puzzle setup: identity and cognitive significance

**Definition 2.1** (Identity)**.** *Identity statements* are statements of the form $a = b$.

- *Law of identity*: everything is identical with itself.
- This implies that any statement that states $a = a$ is *analytically true*, which means that it is true by virtue of what it means alone.

**Note.** Analytic statements normally have low cognitive significance.

**Definition 2.2** (Singular terms)**.** The expressions used to uniquely represent the specific objects $a$ and $b$ are known as *singular terms*.

Sometimes we will come across demonstrative phrases such as "that $x$" or the like. These, like definite descriptions, are also treated as singular terms.

**Definition 2.3** (Cognitive significance)**.** The difference between identity statements, according to Frege, is brought about by *cognitive significance*. It is how much more non-trivial and informative a particular identity statement is when we learn it.

- Only true statements can have cognitive significance, because "learning" and other factive verbs presuppose that the statements are true.

## 2.2 Frege's Referential Theory of Meaning

**Definition 2.4** (Referential Theory of Meaning, RTM)**.** The meaning of an expression is determined by whatever we use that expression to talk about, iff the aspect of meaning contributes to the truth/falsity of a sentence.

These aspects of meaning are known as *semantic values*. They can be used to classify all expressions into four different semantic values:

| Expression | Semantic value |
|---|---|
| Sentences | True/False |
| Names | Objects |
| First-level predicates | First-level functions (map objects to truth values) |
| Second-level predicates (quantifiers) | Second-level functions (map first-level functions to truth values) |

All of the above functions here are *extensional*. In this particular context, that means that two functions are equivalent if and only if their output maps to the same set for every input. (Note that, for both first-level and second-level functions, this equivalence relation partitions the space of first-level and second-level predicates.) If two functions belong to the same equivalence class, then they are known as being *coextensional*.

## 2.3 Critiques of the Referential Theory of Meaning

### Problem 1: Empty names

The meaning of a sentence is its truth-value, according to RTM. Thus, sentences without truth-values are meaningless. However, the truth-value of a sentence depends on the semantic values of its parts, given Compositionality. Specifically, sentences have a truth-value only if the names featuring refer to an object. Thus, if those names are empty, then sentences are meaningless. But this is implausible: we have no trouble understanding what they mean, even if the names featuring fail to refer.

### Problem 2: Cognitive significance

**Definition 2.5** (Synonymy thesis)**.** Sentences that are synonymous cannot differ in cognitive significance.

The Referential Theory directly contrasts the above, because sentences that clearly differ in cognitive significance are exactly the same in terms of all of their semantic values (names, sentences, first-level predicates, etc.).

### Problem 3: Substitution Salva Veritate (SSV)

**Definition 2.6** (Substitution Salva Veritate)**.** If two expressions $a$ and $b$ have the same semantic value, then substituting either within a sentence preserves the semantic value of that particular sentence.

However, propositional attitude verbs break this in half, as in the following example:

**Example 2.7.**

- I believe $1 + 1 = 2$.
- I believe $2 \times 1 = 2$.

The first statement is potentially true, but the second can be false, which contradicts SSV.

If RTM were correct, then sentences differing only in the substitution of expressions having the same semantic values should have the same meaning, and thus truth-value. But this is wrong: sentences differing in this way can have different truth-values.

# Philosophy of Language — Week 3

Fregean Senses and Substitutivity

## 3.1 Senses

**Definition 3.1** (Senses/meaning)**.** Whatever determines semantic value in Frege's Referential Theory of Meaning.

Properties of senses:

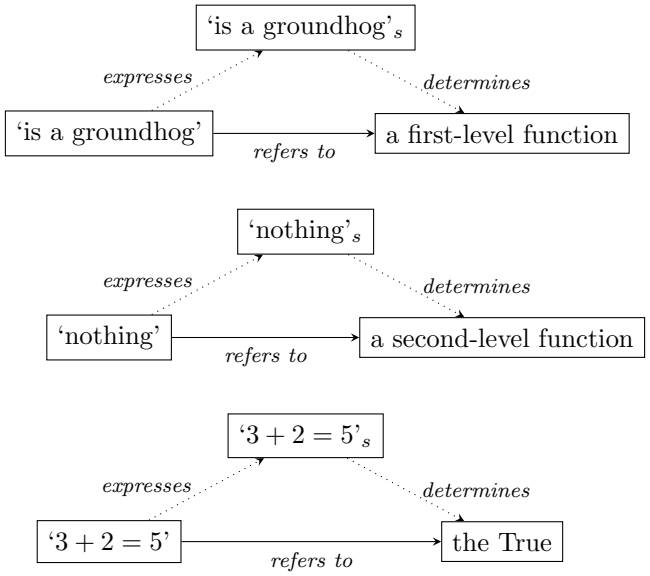
**Property 1:** They determine semantic value.

**Property 2:** They are compositional. Sense is a homomorphism across grammatical operations.

**Property 3:** They are abstract. They exist outside space and time.

**Property 4:** When a sentence is uttered, we grasp or interact with its sense.

## 3.2 The Fregean triangle




1. an expression *expresses* its sense;
2. a sense *determines* a semantic value;
3. an expression *refers* to a semantic value determined by its sense.

**Definition 3.2.** The sense of a sentence is a *thought*.

## 3.3 Frege's antipsychologism

### The problem of communicative success

Suppose meanings were mental entities, e.g. ideas or concepts. Since different people have different ideas or concepts, my meaning of 'dog' might differ from your meaning of 'dog'. But understanding a sentence requires understanding the meanings of the words comprising it, and successful communication requires mutual understanding. Thus, successful communication wouldn't be possible if you understand something different from 'Fido is a dog' than I do. But successful communication is possible.

This implies that senses are not mental entities, and Frege therefore takes an antipsychologist view.

## 3.4 The telescope analogy

Suppose you and I both view Venus through a telescope. A single object—Venus—is projected on the lens of the telescope in both cases, but the same image is projected onto different retinas. Thus, you and I can see the same independently existing object despite processing the image of that object through different physiological means.

1. *The telescope: senses as objective*
    - Venus :: the referent/semantic value of 'Venus'
    - image on the lens :: the objective sense/meaning of 'Venus'
    - image on the retina :: our subjective grasp of this sense
2. *The microscope: logic as a guide to reality*
    - image on the lens :: reality
    - the microscope :: a logically perfect language
    - the eye :: natural language

### 3.4.1 Solving the problem of cognitive significance

- Frege refers to senses as *modes of presentation*.
- Given that senses are inherently distinct as modes of presentation, if there are two different senses, there are two different meanings despite the same referent. Senses are compositional, which means they express different thoughts. We know that thoughts are the sense of a sentence and therefore what we grasp, and then understand. This implies that what we grasp from a sentence with different senses is neither trivial nor uninformative.

### 3.4.2 Solving the problem of empty names

- Sentences all have thoughts and therefore have sense.
- Compositionality implies that all expressions in the sentence also have senses.
- A sense does not require that a referent exists, according to Frege's RTM.
- This implies that all sentences can be meaningful.

### 3.4.3 Solving the problem of Substitution Salva Veritate

Substitution fails within indirect vs direct quotation and propositional attitude verbs. We distinguish between customary sense and indirect referent:

**Definition 3.3.**

- *Customary sense*: the sense/referent of an expression outside the propositional attitude/ quotation.
- *Indirect referent*: the sense/referent of an expression inside the propositional attitude/ quotation.

Frege's solution is that *the indirect referent of an expression is its customary sense.*

What does that mean? Inside a propositional attitude context, an expression refers to what is ordinarily its sense.

Given that the senses in an SSV sentence are not the same, they do not refer to the same thing, and by compositionality the sentences can differ in truth value.

# Philosophy of Language — Week 4

Russell's Theory of Descriptions

**Bertrand Russell**: set theory and logic man. Snyder went through hoops to prove him wrong.

## 4.1 Surface grammar is misleading

- In sentences like "I met a man", expressions like "a man" cannot be singular terms, because they cannot be mapped to single objects (their referent is not a single object), despite the sentence being similar in grammatical structure to "I met Donkey Kong".
- Russell argued that "a man" is instead a second-level function (similar to "there exists a man"). It maps "I met" to a truth value.
- This implies surface grammar cannot be a good guide to meaning.
- This implies there are very few singular terms in Russell's theory of descriptions.

## 4.2 Logical translation

If not grammar, Russell believes you can translate phrases into logical form to find meaning. *Logical form* here just means a translation of a phrase into logic.

## 4.3 The copula

**Definition 4.1.** The predication "to be" is known as the *copula*.

The copula is ambiguous and can have two possible meanings:

- *'Is' of predication*: a copula that predicates a property of a singular term.
- *'Is' of identity*: a copula that identifies the referents of two singular terms.

## 4.4 Types of descriptions

**Definition 4.2** (Indefinite descriptions)**.** Expressions like 'an $F$'. 'An $F$ is $G$' is true if

1. at least one thing is an $F$;
2. that thing is a $G$.

**Definition 4.3** (Definite descriptions)**.** Expressions like 'the $F$'. 'The $F$ is $G$' is true if

1. at least one thing is an $F$;
2. at most one thing is an $F$;
3. whatever is the thing is also $G$.

## 4.5 Differences from Frege

- Russell believed that Frege mislabelled definite descriptions as singular terms; rather, they were quantificational expressions. No other objects could qualify as a singular term according to Russell.
- According to Russell, there was no such thing as senses.

## 4.6 Solving empty definite descriptions

Goofy statements like "the round square" are meaningful because round and square are functions of each other that can exist. While these functions can exist, their composition is mapped to an empty set of objects, and therefore claiming that they exist cannot be true, because no object fulfills the truth condition of both of these functions. Therefore, these statements are false.

## 4.7 Meinong, and the Fregean and Russellian objections

Alexius Meinong held that certain objects, like unicorns etc., hold a certain quality of *subsistence*, or basically a different type of existence. This is *Meinongian ontology*.

Therefore, statements like "Pegasus is a winged horse." were both meaningful and true to him. The argument is as follows: if "Pegasus is a winged horse." is true, then the first-level function in the sentence is mapping an object to true, and the sentence could only be true if the objects were mapped to true; therefore they require a referent, and therefore exist.

**Argument 4.4** (Meinong)**.**

P1) Singular terms that feature in true sentences must have a referent.

P2) "Pegasus" is a singular term in "Pegasus is a winged horse".

P3) "Pegasus is a winged horse" is true.

C) "Pegasus" must have a referent.

- **Frege** rejects this simply because the referents are required to exist and be mapped onto a specific object, and therefore says that this is a load of garbage. As a result of the lack of a referent, the sentence also loses meaning by compositionality. He rejects P3).
- **Russell** works around this by making sure that the expressions themselves are not singular terms that cannot be mapped to a referent, but quantifiers that do not require being mapped to a particular referent that must exist. Even if they are empty, they still mean something. That being said, he rejects P3) on account of the sentence itself being false, as there exists no referent. He rejects P2) on account that "Pegasus" is not a singular term; rather, it is a quantificational operator.

# Philosophy of Language — Week 5

Russell's Solutions to Frege's Problems, and Critiques of the Theory of Descriptions

## 5.1 The problem of negative existentials

Assume the sentence "Pegasus does not exist". For "Pegasus" to have a property, it must be mapped to an object that exists, but the predicate requires that it must not exist, and there seems to be a contradiction.

## 5.2 Collapse of the Fregean Referential Theory of Meaning

**Definition 5.1** (Assumption of reference)**.** All singular terms are assumed to refer.

When we convert the statement into logical form:

P1) There does not exist an object such that it is identical to Pegasus.

P2) Pegasus is a singular term.

P1) and P2) are contradictory because of the assumption of reference.

## 5.3 Russell's solution to empty names

**Note.** In all the solutions below, names like "Pegasus", "Venus" etc. are disguised definite descriptions in the view of Russell.

Consider the sentence (a): "The winged horse of Greek mythology flies". The following argues that Frege's RTM is incorrect:

**Argument 5.2.**

P1) RTM is correct *if and only if* sentences with singular terms are meaningful if those sentences have a referent.

P2) "The winged horse of Greek mythology" is a singular term.

P3) "The winged horse of Greek mythology" does not have a referent.

C1) P1) $\Rightarrow$ (a) is not meaningful.

P4) (a) is meaningful.

C2) RTM is incorrect, by contradiction.

Russell's theory rejects P2) (it is a quantifier instead), and P4) is still true because (a) is assigned a semantic value. Therefore the descriptive theory does hold.

## 5.4 Russell's solution to the problem of substitution

Why RTM collapses for, for example, a propositional attitude sentence:

**Argument 5.3.**

P1) Coreferential singular terms ($a$, $b$) have the same semantic value.

P2) SSV holds for sentences containing the two terms $a$ and $b$.

P3) The definite descriptions of those sentences are coreferential singular terms.

C1) So, the sentences should have the same semantic value.

P4) They don't.

Russell rejects P3), since they are not singular terms.

## 5.5 Russell's solution to the problem of cognitive significance

Why RTM collapses:

**Argument 5.4.**

P1) Coreferential singular terms have the same semantic values.

P2) Expressions having the same meaning are equally informative.

C1) RTM is correct $\Rightarrow$ coreferential singular terms are equally informative.

P3) The definite descriptions in the two identity statements $a = a$ and $a = b$ are coreferential singular terms.

C2) RTM $\Rightarrow$ $a = a$ and $a = b$ are equally informative.

P4) $a = a$ and $a = b$ are not equally informative.

C3) RTM is incorrect.

Russell rejects P3) because (*drumroll*) they are not singular terms.

## 5.6 Russell's solution to the problem of negative existentials

Why RTM collapses: let (a) be "Pegasus exists" and (b) be "Pegasus does not exist".

**Argument 5.5.**

P1) By the law of excluded middle, only (a) or (b) is true.

P2) (a) is true $\Rightarrow$ Pegasus exists.

P3.0) The assumption of reference presupposes the following:

P3) (b) is true $\Rightarrow$ Pegasus does not exist.

P3.1) (b) is true $\Rightarrow$ there exists a Pegasus with the property of not existing.

C1) Due to the contradiction in P3.1), Pegasus exists.

Russell rejects P3.1), not because it is a singular term (surprisingly), but because the predicate "not existing" is ambiguous, with the following two meanings when combined with a definite description:

1. There is exactly one thing such that it is not the case that it is a winged horse.
2. It is not the case that there is exactly one thing such that it is a winged horse.

We can pick the second meaning in order to avoid a collapse of the theory of descriptions.

## 5.7 Critiques of Russell

### Communicative success

- Different people might have distinct definite descriptions, and therefore meanings, attributed to the same name. This should imply that communication as a whole is impossible.
- The description may not be unique/bijective.
- As we will see later, the description might just end up being wrong ("Christopher Columbus" as the first person to discover America).

### Distinct logical forms

Not all logical forms of a sentence are reducible to the same expression. This leads to unsuccessful communication.

### Still unable to fully solve the issue of SSV

- Consider our earlier argument, where we said that coreferential singular terms were what led to the collapse of RTM.
- Replace that with coextensional predicates (same definite descriptions) and the same collapse will occur for the theory of definite descriptions.

## 5.8 Millianism and Russellianism

**Definition 5.6** (Millianism)**.** John Stuart Mill had a philosophy that was often associated with Russellianism. Millianism is essentially just saying that the meaning of a name is its referent.

Frege disagrees, because meaning according to Frege is sense rather than a referent.

**Definition 5.7** (Russellianism)**.** Things that are named by names are constituents of propositions.

Because these named things are parts of a proposition and are required to deconstruct a proposition, Millianism is often associated with Russellianism. However, Russell is not a Millian, because a Millian believes in singular terms. Russell sees the meaning of names not as singular terms but as definite descriptions.

## 5.9 Scope ambiguities

**Definition 5.8.** Sentences which have multiple meanings depending on what kind of scope each function takes are *scope ambiguous*.

Scope ambiguities involving time and negation are in accordance with the tense of the sentence in a Russellian analysis. For example, a "present" king of France vs a "past" king of France being bald changes the semantic value of the sentence entirely.

# Philosophy of Language — Week 6

Strawson on 'Referring'

**Strawson**: "Clever guy" (Eric Snyder). A believer in Ordinary Language Philosophy.

## 6.1 Strawson's three-way distinction

Strawson's three-way distinction that forms propositions:

(a) *A literal sentence/expression.*

(b) *The utterance of a sentence/expression*: the spatio-temporal context in which the sentence was uttered. It is not the utterance itself but the *use* of the sentence (the statement made) that has a truth value; two different uses can make two different statements. When talking about utterances, he is talking about using sentence tokens, but when using "the sentence" he is talking about sentence types.

   i. Because the use has a truth value, the tokens of the sentences determine the truth value rather than the type.

   ii. Expression types have meaning whether or not their presuppositions are met: meaning belongs to the type (the rules and conventions for its use). Presupposition failure only affects whether a use of the sentence is true or false (Strawson's criterion of assertion states that an assertion by a sentence is only true or false if all presuppositions are satisfied).

      - This implies that Strawson does not use the principle of bivalence, which states that sentences can only be mapped to a semantic value of "true" or "false".

   iii. Meanings are given by the conventions and rules determined by how we live our everyday lives.

(c) *The use of a sentence/expression*: the "uniquely referring use" of a particular sentence/ expression to attach to a unique referent.

## 6.2 Neither true nor false statements

If an expression like "the present king of France" is present in a proposition that was uttered now, the proposition is neither true nor false, because there is no referent for the present king of France, the key word being *present*.

## 6.3 Indexicals

**Definition 6.1.** *Indexicals* are linguistic expressions whose reference can shift from context to context. These are words like 'I', 'you', 'here', 'there'.

Given how Strawson defines utterances and uses, two utterances of the same sentence type containing indexicals never have the same use. This is because they shift from context to context, and therefore have a different usage with a different time and spatial context.

## 6.4 Entailment and presupposition

**Definition 6.2** (Entailment)**.** A relation holding between (sets of) propositions, whereby $p$ entails $q$ if it is impossible for $p$ to be true while $q$ is false.

- If $p \Rightarrow q$, then $p$ entails $q$.

**Definition 6.3** (Presupposition)**.** A different relation holding between (sets of) propositions. Very roughly, $p$ presupposes $q$ if anyone sincerely asserting $p$ believes, and expects their interlocutors to also believe, $q$.

- If $p \Rightarrow q$ and $\neg p \Rightarrow q$, then $p$ *presupposes* $q$.

There is also the family of sentences test:

**The Family of Sentences Test.** A sentence $S$ presupposes a sentence $S'$ if (i) $S$ takes for granted $S'$ and

(ii) 'It's not the case that $S$' takes for granted $S'$

(iii) 'If $S$, then ...' takes for granted $S'$

(iv) 'It might be that $S$' takes for granted $S'$

(v) 'Is it the case that $S$?' takes for granted $S'$

## 6.5 Strawson's account of meaning

Definite descriptions *presuppose* existence. They do *not entail* existence.

**Example 6.4.**

(6a) The king of France is wise.

(6b) There is a king of France.

In light of this, why does Strawson write the following?

*There are at least two true things which Russell would say about the sentence [in (6a)]:*

*(1) The first is that it is significant; that if anyone were now to utter it, he would be uttering a significant sentence.*

*(2) The second is that anyone now uttering the sentence would be making a true assertion only if there in fact at present existed one and only one king of France, and if he were wise.*

*What are the false things which Russell would say about the sentence [in (6a)]? They are:*

*(1) That anyone now uttering it would be making a true assertion or a false assertion.*

*(2) That part of what he would be asserting would be that there at present existed one and only one king of France.*

**Definition 6.5** (Strawson's Criterion of Assertion)**.** An utterance of a sentence $S$ makes an assertion which is true or false only if all of $S$'s presuppositions are satisfied. Otherwise, an utterance of $S$ is neither true nor false.

## 6.6 Strawson's critiques of Russell

### Objection 1: The bearers of truth and falsity

Russell maintains that:

P1) Every grammatical sentence type expresses a *unique* proposition.

P2) Every proposition is either true or false.

Strawson responded with:

1. Without additional context/presuppositions, we cannot know if a sentence is true or false, which contradicts P2).
2. Consider Strawson's example (7): 'This is a fine red one.' In different contexts, different assertions are made, and those assertions may be true or false, depending on what the speaker is doing and whether it is red. But then the sentence type (7) cannot be said to express something true or false, but rather an utterance of that sentence, or rather a speaker's use of a token of that sentence type to make an assertion. This contradicts P1).

### Objection 2: Incomplete descriptions

Why Russell's theory of descriptions collapses for definite descriptions. Consider

**Example 6.6.** (8) The table is covered with books.

**Argument 6.7.**

P1) If Russell's theory of descriptions is correct, then (8) would be true only if there is exactly one table in the universe.

P2) There is more than one table in the universe.

C1) So, if Russell's theory of descriptions is correct, then (8) must be false.

P3) (8) needn't be false: in fact, it may be true.

C2) Therefore, Russell's theory of descriptions is not correct.

There are two potential responses: the *elliptical response* and *quantifier domain restriction*.

**Elliptical response.**

1. Definite descriptions like 'the table' are actually elliptical for more complex descriptions like 'the table located in Room AC201 of Ashoka University . . . '. In other words, 'the table' in (8) really means 'the table . . . '. So long as there is enough elided material in '. . . ' to uniquely pick out a single table, (8) may be true.
2. Think of the ellipses as being *silent*.
3. Problems with the elliptical response:
   (a) The elliptical material can be infinite, and can be further complex due to the definite description of the table containing multiple other definite descriptions.
   (b) Sentence types with and without the definite description are distinct. This means that both sentences express the same proposition, which contradicts Russell's view that they must express unique ones.

**Quantifier domain restriction.**

1. The quantifiers within a sentence essentially cover only a certain domain, which allows us to say "the table" after setting up a domain that is not the universe.
2. Problems with this for Russell's theory:
   (a) Since we are doing all the work of restricting the domain, we don't really need Russell's theory.
   (b) Russell wouldn't be comfortable with the truth/falsity of a sentence fluctuating across different domains.
   (c) "If a bishop meets another bishop, the bishop blesses the other bishop." Good luck restricting the domain for this.

# Philosophy of Language — Week 7

Grice's Theory of Implicature

## 7.1 Paul Grice

Grice was a defender of the following:

i. Natural language meaning is reducible to speakers' intentions, and thus to speakers' psychology (since intentions are mental states). He advocated for psychologism.

ii. Not all aspects of natural language meaning are conventional. There is also an aspect contributed by what speakers intend to convey in a given context, consistent with certain general rules governing conversation.

## 7.2 Grice's categorisation of Strawson, Frege and Russell

**Definition 7.1** (Formalists)**.** Grice thought that Frege and Russell were *formalists*. Formalists think that natural language arguments should be translated into a system of formal logic, where the validity or invalidity of an argument depends on whether statements of the same form generally preserve the truth of a conclusion given the truth of the premises. Formalists construct ideal logical languages.

**Definition 7.2** (Informalists)**.** Grice thought that Strawson was an *informalist*. Informalists think that the construction of an ideal logical language rests on certain faulty assumptions:

i) that the adequacy of language is to be determined by how well it can serve the purposes of science;

ii) that an expression is intelligible only if it can be regimented in a manner analysable in terms of symbols like '$\neg$' or '$\wedge$';

iii) that definitions are acceptable only if they can be expressed as logical equivalences.

Many arguments in natural language are valid even if they do not fit a valid logical form, and so a less formal, more simplified way of determining acceptable forms of reasoning is required.

## 7.3 Implicature

**Definition 7.3** (Implicature)**.** If $q$ is an *implicature* of $p$, then $q$ could be either true or false when $p$ is true. Compare entailment: if $q$ is an entailment of $p$, then $q$ cannot be false when $p$ is true.

- Entailment is a *semantic* relation. It concerns what is true of the conventional meaning of the sentence.

- Implicature is a *pragmatic* relation. It concerns what we can infer based on a speaker's likely intentions given the circumstances of an utterance.
- Test: if $p \wedge q$ and $\neg q \wedge p$ can both occur, then q is an implicature of p. Else $p \wedge q$ and $\neg p \wedge \neg q$ and $\neg p \wedge q$ is an entailment.
- Implicatures are also *cancelable*, meaning they can be taken back without a contradiction (i.e. $\neg q$ without implying $\neg p$).

## 7.4 Types of implicature and Grice's maxims

**Definition 7.4** (Types of implicature)**.**

i. *Conventional*: implicatures resulting from the conventional meanings of words or phrases, e.g. 'but' implicates contrast.

ii. *Conversational*: implicatures resulting from assumptions required to ensure that speakers are being cooperative (or why they aren't).

**Definition 7.5** (Cooperative principle)**.** The main maxim for conversational implicatures: make your conversational contribution such as is required, at the stage at which it occurs, by the accepted purpose or direction of the talk exchange in which you are engaged.

Sub-maxims of the cooperative principle:

i. *Maxim of quantity*: provide the right amount of information (not too little, not much more).

ii. *Maxim of quality*: be accurate (try to make the statement true).

iii. *Maxim of relation*: be relevant.

iv. *Maxim of manner*: be perspicuous (be clear).

## 7.5 Meaning according to Grice

**Definition 7.6.**

- *Conventional meaning* (or *non-natural meaning*) is what is conveyed by linguistic and cultural conventions like sarcasm etc.
- *Speaker meaning* is the meaning conveyed by the utterance itself (conveyed meaning).
- *Natural meaning*: meaning which is not conventional.

Metalinguistic negation ("I didn't just giggle, I LAUGHED"), sarcasm and irony are examples where conventional meaning and speaker meaning differ.

**Definition 7.7** (Invited inferences)**.** Inferences hearers are invited to make given what was said and the circumstances in which an utterance takes place (asked to evaluate if there is an inference).

- These are a subset of conversational implicatures.
- These have to be both calculable and cancelable.

**Example 7.8.**

1. An utterance of 'Mary and John fell in love and got married' invites the inference that they fell in love before getting married.
2. An utterance of 'Mary and John fell in love and got married' implicates that they fell in love before getting married. Again, the order in which conjoined clauses are uttered often suggests that one action described happened before another. Thus, 'Mary and John got married and fell in love' suggests that they got married before falling in love. Thus, the fact that a speaker chose to order the clauses in the manner they did suggests they intend to convey that the events described happened in the order suggested, and the Maxim of Manner requires that speakers be orderly. Moreover, the implicature is cancelable: one can consistently follow this up with 'Oh, and by the way, they got married before falling in love'.

**Definition 7.9** (Calculability)**.** We must be able to give an argument based on Grice's maxims where obeying or failing to obey a certain maxim or maxims serves as a premise, and the implicature generated serves as a conclusion.

- All calculable inferences are conversational, and vice versa.

## 7.6 Grice's Razor

**Definition 7.10** (Grice's Razor)**.** Do not postulate ambiguities beyond necessity.

In other words, if we can explain multiple interpretations of a sentence pragmatically (via implicature) rather than semantically (by postulating an ambiguity in any of the words contained), then we should do that.

Third explanation: if there is an ambiguity, use an implicature to explain it.

- Furthermore, this puts Strawson's theory of meaning in jeopardy, because Grice suggests that sentences without "any truth value" can be designated true or false regardless, thanks to implicature. For example, "The present king of France is bald" can be followed up with "Wait a minute, there isn't a king of France."

## 7.7 Objections to Grice's theory

According to Grice, sentences have meaning due to speakers uttering them with an intention to spark a corresponding belief in their audience. However, this collapses in the following scenarios:

i. *Audienceless utterances*: talking to myself.

ii. *Absence of intention*: saying something without the intent of inducing a belief, such as a student answering a question for somebody who already knows the answer and is convinced of the belief.

iii. *Opposite intention*: saying things to inspire a belief contrary to what was said.

iv. *Recursion*: there are indefinitely many meaningful sentences in natural language, and it is impossible to utter them all with some intention.

# Philosophy of Language — Week 8

Quine's Two Dogmas

**Quine**: interesting maths boi. He came about during the era of logical empiricism. There were three parts of the movement at the time:

(a) *Empiricism*: generally, empiricism claims that the primary source of knowledge is sense experience. It is the primary means by which we gain (scientific) knowledge, excepting logic and mathematics.

(b) *Verificationism*: sentences are meaningful only if (i) they are analytic, or else (ii) they could be confirmed or disconfirmed by experience.

(c) *Anti-metaphysics*: statements which cannot be (dis)confirmed by experience are literally meaningless. These include statements of theology ('God is all-knowing'), ethics ('Giving to charity is good'), and metaphysics ('Being is the positive moment or thesis').

Quine had some issues with verificationism specifically, as well as with the definition of analyticity.

## 8.1 Verificationism

**Definition 8.1** (Verificationism)**.** The meaning of a sentence consists in its method of empirical confirmation or disconfirmation. Specifically, the meaning of a sentence $S$ is its *verification conditions*, i.e. the conditions in which $S$ would tend to be (dis)confirmed by experience. We might think of these as the set of possible experiences which would tend to confirm $S$.

i. A sentence in verificationism is *analytic* if it is synonymous with a logical truth.

ii. Two sentences are *synonymous* if they have the same verification conditions. This implies that analytic sentences are confirmed by all possible experiences.

### Objections to verificationism

**Objection 8.2** (Meaning is not verifiability)**.** We cannot know if $S$ can be disconfirmed by an experience before knowing its meaning $\Rightarrow$ the meaning of $S$ cannot be its verification conditions.

**Objection 8.3** (Verificationism is self-refuting)**.** There is no possible set of experiences to confirm verificationism, at least none that we can zero in on $\Rightarrow$ either verificationism is meaningless or analytic, and there is absolutely no reason for verificationism to be analytic.

**Objection 8.4** (Quine's objection: the fun one)**.** Verificationism presupposes that meaningful sentences can be divided into two kinds: those which are (dis)confirmed by experience and those which are analytic. But there are no analytic sentences. In fact, there is no such thing as meaning!

## 8.2 Synthetic vs analytic sentences

**Definition 8.5.**

i. *Analytic sentences*: true in virtue of meaning alone.

ii. *Synthetic sentences*: true in virtue of how the world happens to be, i.e. can be confirmed by experience.

### Characterisations of analytic sentences, according to Quine

**Kant.**

1. A subject-predicate sentence is analytic if the concept expressed by the subject is "already contained" within, or is subordinate to, the concept expressed by the predicate (coextensional).

2. A sentence is analytic if its denial results in a contradiction. For example, if we deny that "bachelors are unmarried", then it contradicts the definition of a bachelor ("bachelors are unmarried") and therefore results in a contradiction.

**Frege.**

1. A sentence is analytic if it is a logical law or else is derivable from logical laws and suitable definitions alone.

## 8.3 Quine's attack on analyticity

**Definition 8.6** (Quine's Socratic assumption)**.** A characterisation of analyticity is acceptable only if it takes the form

$$\text{A sentence } S \text{ is analytic iff it is } _____,$$

where the blank is filled with something independently understandable, and the definition is not circular (i.e. it does not rely on analyticity to be understood).

Quine's objection is that all three assumptions fail to meet the above definition:

(a) Kant's first characterisation, "already contained", is metaphorical. It applies only to sentences with "general terms".

(b) Kant's second characterisation, contradiction, also collapses. Suppose we take this to be true, and we want to check if the phrase "bachelors are unmarried" is an analytic phrase. The denial of the phrase is not directly in the form of a contradiction, but we know that due to synonymy (which we do not have any notion of), it contradicts the statement that "bachelors are unmarried". Therefore, we need a definition of analyticity (statements that must be true) to create a contradiction, leading to circular reasoning.

(c) Frege's characterisation collapses due to a reliance on "suitable definitions", which is unclear and unspecified.

## 8.4 Quine's attack on synonymy

These are the characterisations of synonymy according to Quine. Some of our critiques earlier when it comes to substitutivity are criticisms Quine shares:

1. *Extensional substitutivity*: two expressions are synonymous if and only if they are substitutable salva veritate.
    (a) We have already proved that SSV collapses if put into an intensional language like English (there are many examples of SSV failing due to propositional attitude... yeah, I'll save it). Quine formalises this by saying that when it comes to an extensional language, SSV guarantees only coextensiveness and not synonymy.
2. *Necessary substitutivity*: two expressions are synonymous if and only if they are necessarily substitutable salva veritate.
    (a) I guess we control when we can use SSV, but then this makes synonymy just as vague as analyticity.

## 8.5 Consequences of these attacks

**No synthetic/analytic distinction.**

1. We don't know what is analytic anymore, or what is true in virtue of meaning alone. We can no longer distinguish sentences like these from statements derived from empirical fact.
2. This undermines verificationism.

**Skepticism about meaning.**

1. Skepticism about analyticity $\Rightarrow$ skepticism about meaning.
2. There is no fact that governs meaning.

## 8.6 Confirmation holism

Confirmation holism is one outlet of Quine's skepticism about meaning. We can hold two kinds of belief structure:

**Definition 8.7.**

1. *Foundationalism*: there are certain primal beliefs that cannot be justified but justify other beliefs, and we build our belief system on them.
2. *Holism*: our beliefs form an interconnected web. No belief is immune to rational revision; they are justified together. However, there is a scale of how prone certain beliefs are to rational revision (those on the periphery of the interconnected web).

**Quine's confirmation holism.**

1. Quine was an empiricist, which means he believed that experience was the primary method of obtaining knowledge.

2. Combine the above with holism, and you get a holistic belief system where rational revision happens through experience. Experience confirms the entire system of beliefs (the web).
3. Due to the nature of the above, there is no analytic/synthetic distinction between beliefs.

## 8.7 Quine's meaning eliminativism

Meaning eliminativism is the more direct outlet of Quine's skepticism about meaning.

### 8.7.1 Radical translation

**Example 8.8** (Thought experiment)**.**

(a) I speak Dingleberry and walk up to you.

(b) I point at an anthill and go "globlglob".

(c) You will have literally no idea what I am talking about if that is the first time you've heard me speak Dingleberry. Am I talking about the ants? An anteater? An anthill? Pain? All very valid hypotheses.

(d) You call over somebody else. They point and either go "globglobg" or "binglebongle". You are still left confused.

(e) Quine repeated this thought experiment in a more interesting way, and said that any hypothesis of meaning is vastly undetermined by the evidence.

### 8.7.2 Meaning eliminativism

**Definition 8.9** (Meaning eliminativism)**.** There is no such thing as linguistic meaning, as shown from the above, assuming our system of belief is confirmation holism.

**Argument 8.10.**

P1) If there is no empirical fact as to what expressions mean, then meanings should not feature as posits of our best scientific theories.

P2) We ought to accept the existence of only those things that are required to make our best scientific theories true, including what they posit (from Quine's ontology).

C2) Therefore, we deny the existence of meaning.

### 8.7.3 Objections to Quine's meaning eliminativism

**Objection 8.11** (From logical truths)**.** As a logician, Quine accepts the existence of logical truths. But it is arguable that the notion of logical truth presupposes a notion of meaning. That's because there are sentences which have the form of a logical truth but contain words that are lexically ambiguous.

**Objection 8.12** (From necessity)**.** Quine argues that synonymy depends on necessity, which is just as unclear as analyticity. Kripke later clarified necessity using modal logic.

**Objection 8.13** (From modern science)**.** Quine believes that we must deny the existence of meaning in order to accept the empirical facts that contribute to our best scientific theories. However, linguistic semantics, a scientific field, posits meanings as a part of its best theories. Hence, a contradiction.

# Philosophy of Language — Week 9

Tarski and Davidson: Obsession for Truth

**Tarski**: Banach–Tarski paradox and all. I love all these mathematicians coming in here, hehehe.

## 9.1 Tarski's aim

Tarski aims to provide a rigorous and consistent definition of truth, or of a predicate like 'is true', for a language $L$. It should meet the two conditions below:

(a) *Formal correctness*: the definition should be a biconditional, similar to our definition of analyticity. It should also be derivable from a metalanguage not containing the definition of 'true'.

(b) *Material adequacy*: All and only sentences characterised by the *T-schema* (which we define below) should be categorised as true sentences in $L$.

## 9.2 The T-schema

**Definition 9.1** (T-schema)**.**

$$S \text{ is true if and only if } p.$$

$S$ ranges over the *object language* and $p$ ranges over the *meta language*.

Given that 'is true' is a predicate, it has an extension over all true statements, and therefore the schema can be modified for all true sentences $x$:

$$\text{For all } x,\ x \text{ is true if and only if } p.$$

## 9.3 Candidates for truth

(a) *Fregean view*: truth is an object (the True). The True can be related as a referent to any particular sentence that is true. It is the possible referent of that sentence.

(b) *Property view*: semantically, 'is true' is a predicate that accepts one argument. It is a property of sentences or propositions. **Tarski opts for this view.**

## 9.4 Theories of truth as a predicate

**Definition 9.2.**

(a) *Deflationary theories*: saying '$S$ is true' is synonymous with just saying '$S$'.

(b) *Correspondence theories*: $S$ is true iff $S$ expresses a fact, i.e. is in a relation with reality. Tarski's T-schema should ideally capture this intuition.

(c) *Pragmatist/utilitarian theories*: $S$ is true iff $S$ is useful to believe in.

(d) *Coherence theories*: $S$ is true iff $S$ coheres with one's interconnected network of beliefs.

## 9.5 The liar's paradox

(a) Consider the sentence uttered by a liar: *This sentence is false.*

(b) It contradicts itself regardless of its overall semantic value.

(c) This led Tarski to believe that defining the predicate for natural language would be absolutely useless.

(d) Tarski stated that this paradox arose from three assumptions within all natural languages:

i. The language the sentence is formed in can be used to state facts about its own semantics.

ii. The law of the excluded middle (a sentence must be true or false, not both nor neither) holds.

iii. The language the liar speaks in is the same language we use to process it.

(e) He then said fuck it, let me do it for maths and science instead.

## 9.6 Reference-relation types

According to Tarski there are two kinds of *reference-relations* (relations between an expression and an object/part of the real world):

**Definition 9.3.**

i. *Designation*: a relation between singular terms and objects.

ii. *Satisfaction*: a relation between sets of objects and predicates.

## 9.7 A demonstration of Tarski's definition of truth for the natural numbers constructed by the Peano axioms

Tarski's definition for First Order Peano Arithmetic has the following two kinds of axioms:

1. **designation axioms**: axioms specifying what singular terms designate
   - '0' designates the number zero
   - '$s(0)$' designates the successor of zero
2. **satisfaction axioms**: axioms specifying the satisfaction of predicates
   - $x$ satisfies '$Ex$' iff $x$ is a even
   - a pair of objects $x$ and $y$ satisfy '$Lxy$' iff $x$ is less than $y$

We can extend satisfaction to complex formulas using logical connectives:

- $x$ satisfies '$\neg Fx$' iff $x$ is not an $F$

- $x$ satisfies '$Fx \wedge Gx$' iff $x$ is both an $F$ and a $G$
- $x$ satisfies '$Fx \vee Gx$' iff $x$ is an $F$ or a $G$ (possibly both)

And we can also extend satisfaction to quantifiers:

- $x$ satisfies '$\exists x\, \phi$' iff $x$ satisfies $\phi$ on at least one variable assignment
- $x$ satisfies '$\forall x\, \phi$' iff $x$ satisfies $\phi$ on every variable assignment

Note that all relations are not symmetric.

## 9.8 Truth in terms of satisfaction for artificial languages

Remember that satisfaction is a relation for predicates. The following phrases truth as one such relation:

**Definition 9.4.** A (closed) sentence $S$ is true iff '$S$' is satisfied by all variable assignments (VAs).

A demonstration, once again with the first-order Peano axioms:

(8) $\exists x(Ex \vee L0x)$

We can give the truth-conditions for (8) by using the definitions above:

- '$\exists x(Ex \vee L0x)$' is true iff '$\exists x(Ex \vee L0x)$' is satisfied by all VAs
- '$\exists x(Ex \vee L0x)$' is satisfied by all VAs iff some VA satisfies '$Ex \vee L0x$'
- Some VA satisfies '$Ex \vee L0x$' iff it satisfies '$Ex$' or '$L0x$'
- A VA satisfies '$Ex$' or '$L0x$' iff at least one object $x$ is even or $0 < x$
- '$\exists x(Ex \vee L0x)$' is true iff at least one object $x$ is even or $0 < x$

## 9.9 Avoiding paradoxes like the liar's paradox

(a) Let there be a language $L_0$.

(b) A vital part of the paradox is that sentences in the language of the liar are allowed to make statements about their own semantics, implying that the object language of the liar is also its meta language.

(c) Let us make that not so for $L_0$. 'Is true' is not a predicate you will find within $L_0$. Rather, you will find the predicate 'is true' for $L_0$ in its meta language $L_1$. Let this predicate be labelled $\mathrm{T}_1$. Its domain is all sentences of $L_0$.

(d) $\mathrm{T}_1$ is not a truth predicate for its own language. That belongs to the meta language of $L_1$, namely $L_2$. This predicate only applies to T-sentences of $L_1$.

(e) We can keep going for artificial languages until we get **Tarski's hierarchy**.

(f) Given that no sentence in the object language can state its own semantic value, we have kept the meta and object languages separate. We have patched out the paradoxes.

## 9.10 Davidson

(a) **He wanted to take the above theory and apply it to natural languages.**

(b) Tarski thought of T-sentences as "partial definitions" (subsets) of the extension of a truth-predicate for a formal language. Davidson instead understands them as specifying **truth conditions**, which to Davidson are **meanings**, of natural language sentences.

(c) This can also be used to translate across different languages by switching around the hierarchy of object and meta language.

## 9.11 Three conditions for a theory of meaning for natural languages

### 9.11.1 Extensional adequacy

**Definition 9.5** (Extensional adequacy)**.** The theory must generate accurate meanings for all and only the sentences of a language $L$, and it must do so in a purely extensional way.

i. Most semantic theories take the form "$a$ in $L$ means $x$". This makes the context **intensional**. We don't want this, because this context is dependent on the functionality of "means". This is why Frege tried to distinguish sense from reference.

ii. Davidson seems to suggest that any theory of natural language meaning which gives the meanings of natural language expressions in intensional terms presupposes the very notion it should try to explain, namely meaning. So, to avoid circularity, a theory of meaning must be extensional.

iii. Extensional adequacy throws out concepts we find problematic or vague, such as:

   (a) Semantic theories whose meta language invokes intensional entities, for example meta languages that invoke:

      (a) Fregean senses (the thought that snow is white);
      (b) possible worlds (the set of all worlds where snow is white);
      (c) hyperintensional entities (properties etc.).

   (b) Translating sentences of natural language into a metalanguage that introduces intensional contexts, for example propositional attitude verbs, adverbs like "necessarily", noun phrases like "the $x$", etc.

iv. Extensional adequacy does allow translation of sentences of natural language into purely extensional meta languages, such as First Order Predicate Logic (FOPL) or set theory.

### 9.11.2 Compositionality

**Definition 9.6.** All meanings must be compositional (the return of the homomorphism).

Compositionality not only allows us to understand complex constructions in $L$, but also explains why we can learn languages. Understanding a language requires learning units of meaning plus general rules for syntactically and semantically combining them, sufficient for understanding indefinitely many sentences.

### 9.11.3 Charitability

**Definition 9.7.** In accordance with certain principles of interpretation, we must correctly interpret the speakers of a language $L$.

Using the T-schema invokes two problems that can be solved by principles of interpretation:

1. *Correct translation*: a sentence of the metalanguage $p$ provides correct truth-conditions for a sentence of the object language $S$ only if $p$ correctly translates $S$. But "correct translation" presupposes that $S$ and $p$ mean the same thing. So Davidson needs to assume a notion of meaning.

2. *The T-schema overgenerates (return of substitution)*: as formulated by the T-schema, $p$ provides necessary and sufficient conditions for the truth of $S$. However, this only requires that $S$ and $p$ have the same truth-value. Thus, any sentence having the same truth-value as $p$ can be substituted for $p$, resulting in a true instance of the T-schema. For example, 'Snow is white' is true if and only if grass is green. But surely 'Snow is white' does not mean that grass is green!

Our makeshift solution: we can specify "constitutive constraints" on correct translation which do not assume a notion of meaning. If we interpret speakers charitably, as holding beliefs which are, according to us, mostly true, then we can rule out "rogue T-sentences" by considering what else speakers likely believe.

## 9.12 Objections to Davidson

**Objection 9.8** (Natural language is not extensional)**.** By now, given the problems of SSV, it is pretty obvious why natural language cannot be extensional. It obliterates the meanings of predicates that apply to the same set.

**Objection 9.9** (Extensional adequacy can be undermined)**.** In order for certain sentences to make sense, Davidson has allowed for some exceptions:

1. I'm sitting now.

2. (1) is true relative to speaker $s$ and time $t$ (in English) iff $t$ is the time of utterance and $s$ is sitting at $t$ (note that this is brought about because of indexicals).

However, due to these exceptions, there isn't a limit on including intensional entities, and our entire motivation for extensional adequacy is thrown out of the window.

**Objection 9.10** (Anti-reductionism)**.** Davidson's argument against intensional theories being used to define meaning can be interpreted as follows:

P1) A reductive explanation of $X$s is appropriate iff it (the explanation) does not refer to or presuppose prior knowledge of $X$s.

P2) A semantic theory should be a reductive explanation of what meanings are.

C1) No semantic theory should refer to or presuppose prior knowledge of meanings.

P3) Intensional semantic theories do refer to/presuppose prior knowledge of meanings.

C2) Intensional semantic theories are inappropriate to refer to prior knowledge of meanings.

P2) is a heavy premise to assume, and anti-reductionists mainly oppose this same premise.

*Objection*: not all theories of $X$s are intended to be reductive explanations of what $X$s are; for example, set theory.

# Philosophy of Language — Week 10

Kripke, Naming and Necessity

**Saul Kripke**: Snyder's Noether. The God in his eyes. Resurrector of metaphysics.

## 10.1 Deconstructing descriptivism

Types of descriptivism that Kripke identified:

**Definition 10.1.**

i. *Fregean/Russell descriptivism*: names are synonymous with definite descriptions.

ii. *Cluster theory*: names are synonymous with clusters of definite descriptions.

**Argument 10.2** (Kripke against descriptivism)**.** "Desc." refers to both Fregean descriptions and cluster descriptions.

P1) If descriptivism were correct, then for any name $a$ there would be a $d \in$ Desc. such that the statement '$a$ is $d$' is (i) analytic, (ii) knowable a priori, (iii) necessarily true.

P2) There exists an $a$ such that there does not exist a $d$ for which the above three properties are fulfilled.

C) Descriptivism is incorrect and does not hold.

**Definition 10.3** (The three properties)**.**

i. *Analyticity*: true in virtue of meaning alone, for example definitions.

- Contrast, *syntheticity*: true in virtue of how the world is.

ii. *Knowable a priori*: knowable independently of experience, for example mathematical statements.

- Contrast, *a posteriori*: knowledge dependent on experience.

iii. *Necessarily true*: true in all possible worlds, for example the law of self-identity.

- Contrast, *contingent*: may or may not be true.

**Note.** Analyticity entails the other two properties.

## 10.2 The metaphysical argument against descriptivism

### 10.2.1 Modal logic

To be very honest with you, the slides do an excellent job here, and I am going to leave them to do their job, except for one note. You might notice that the relation of accessibility should be a

little more sharply defined, considering that the two modal operators rely on accessing different worlds. The best answer I found was from this guy on StackExchange, which works for the purpose of these notes:

1. Assume we are using a variable domain approach, as David Lewis does to preserve his counterparts. If you have defined a proper model, you know that $R(w_1, w_2)$ if in your model the pair $(w_1, w_2)$ is in the extension of $R$. If you do not have a model, you may be able to infer this from the presumed properties of $R$; for example, from $R(w_0, w_1)$ and $R(w_0, w_2)$ you can infer $R(w_1, w_2)$ if $R$ is Euclidean. You define this relation in the way that characterizes the modality in question. You need to have an idea what properties the respective modality has in the first place.
2. The last two sentences are a little beyond the scope of this course and I am going to leave it alone now. For now, assume that within a certain possibility, if it is not possible to contain a relation within those laws or a certain modality, it is simply inaccessible.

The modern notion of necessity comes from **modal logic**: the logic of possibility and necessity. Its semantics is due to Kripke, who introduces two key notions:

1. **possible worlds**: There are innumerable ways the world could have been: dinosaurs may have survived, Miley Cyrus could have been President, etc. For each way the world could be, there is a possible world in which things are that way. Formally, we can think of these as just points.
2. **accessibility**: Possible worlds are related to one another through the relation of accessibility. Intuitively, a possible world $w_2$ is accessible from world $w_1$ if $w_2$ is possible given how things are in $w_1$. There are various formal properties we can impose on the accessibility relation (reflexivity, symmetry, transitivity, etc), resulting in different *systems* of modal logic.

We can think of different modal systems as modeling different kinds of possibility:

- **epistemic possibility**: what's possible given what we know
- **deontic possibility**: what's possible given the laws of morality
- **physical possibility**: what's possible given the laws of physics
- **logical possibility**: what's possible given the laws of logic
- **metaphysical possibility**: what's possible given the "laws of metaphysics"

**Necessity and Possibility.** Modal logic introduces two operators: '$\Box$' (necessity) and '$\Diamond$' (possibility). Their semantics is given as follows, for any proposition $p$:

1. '$\Box p$' is true at $w$ iff $p$ is true at all worlds accessible from $w$
2. '$\Diamond p$' is true at $w$ iff $p$ is true at least one world accessible from $w$

Given these definitions, we can distinguish between:

1. **necessary truths**: statements true in all accessible worlds
2. **necessary falsehoods**: statements false in all accessible worlds
3. **contingencies**: statements true in some but not all accessible worlds

### 10.2.2 The argument

**Argument 10.4** (Metaphysical argument)**.**

P0) Assume 'Aristotle' and 'the best student of Plato' are synonymous.

P1) If descriptivism were correct, then 'Aristotle is the best student of Plato' would be analytic, and thus necessarily true.

P2) The above sentence is contingent.

C) The descriptive theory is wrong.

## 10.3 The semantic argument against descriptivism

### 10.3.1 Rigid designation

**Definition 10.5.**

i. *Designator*: a coverall term for singular terms: expressions whose semantic function is to refer to particular objects, such as names and definite descriptions.

ii. *Rigid designator*: a designator that refers to the same thing in every possible world in which that thing exists.

**Rigidity implies necessity of identity.** Suppose '$\alpha$' and '$\beta$' are rigid designators, and suppose '$\alpha = \beta$' is true. Then in the actual world, '$\alpha$' and '$\beta$' refer to the same thing, say $y$. But since '$\alpha$' and '$\beta$' are rigid, they refer to $y$ in all possible worlds (in which $y$ exists). But then in every possible world, '$\alpha = \beta$' is true. In other words, '$\alpha = \beta$' is necessarily true.

### 10.3.2 The argument

**Argument 10.6** (Semantic argument)**.**

P1) If descriptivism were correct, then 'Aristotle' and 'the best student of Plato' would both be rigid designators, referring to Aristotle in all possible worlds.

P2) 'Aristotle', but not 'the best student of Plato', is a rigid designator.

C) Thus, descriptivism cannot be correct.

## 10.4 The epistemic argument against descriptivism

(This guy fucking hated descriptivism.)

**Argument 10.7** (Epistemic argument)**.**

P1) If descriptivism were correct, then identity statements of the form '$\alpha$ is the $\delta$' would be analytic, and thus knowable a priori. Hence:

   i. Speakers knowing the meaning of '$\alpha$' should also know a specific description $\delta$ which distinguishes the referent of '$\alpha$' from everything else.

   ii. Speakers should not be able to use '$\alpha$' to refer to $\alpha$ if something other than $\alpha$ is the actual referent of 'the $\delta$'.

**Example 10.8** (Counterexample)**.** Many people know that Richard Feynman and Murray Gell-Mann are famous physicists. But this is probably all they know. Thus, they don't know a specific $\delta$ which would distinguish Feynman from Gell-Mann. Yet they can refer to both using their names.

## 10.5 Necessity, a prioricity and analyticity

All the above arguments are different types of arguments based on analyticity (semantic), necessity (metaphysical) and a prioricity (epistemic). There are examples where one property can be absent (analyticity still entails the other two, though):

i. *Necessary a posteriori*: knowable only empirically, while still being necessarily true, which implies a lack of a prioricity. For example, "water is $H_2O$", which, while true, is only knowable through experience.

ii. *Contingent a priori*: true in some but not all worlds, but knowable independently of experience. For example, "The length of the standard meter stick $S$ is one meter", where the length is a non-rigid designator.

## 10.6 Direct reference and causal reference theory (post-Kripkeans)

**Definition 10.9** (Direct reference theory)**.** The meaning of a name is its referent. That is, at least for names, there is no distinction between meaning and reference.

**Semantics vs metasemantics.**

1. *Semantic theories*: a theory telling us what any name means (descriptivism, direct reference theory).

2. *Metasemantic theories*: a theory telling us why the reference-relation holds between a name and its referent, if it holds at all. The causal theory is hinted at for this one.

**Definition 10.10** (Causal theory of reference)**.**

i. For a name '$\alpha$', an *initial baptism* happens, in one of two ways:

   (a) via *ostension*: by pointing directly at an object and dubbing it '$\alpha$';

   (b) via *description*: by giving a description '$\delta$' and declaring that the referent of '$\alpha$' is to be whatever uniquely satisfies '$\delta$'.

ii. The initial baptism fixes the referent of '$\alpha$'.

iii. The name is then passed from the initial dubber to other speakers, who use the name with the intention of referring to the same object.

iv. This establishes a causal link between the referent and subsequent users of the name.

v. The name continues being passed in this manner, from speaker to speaker, establishing a causal-historical link between speakers and the referent.

vi. It is in virtue of there being a causal chain linking any user of the name and the referent that speakers manage to successfully refer to that thing using '$\alpha$'. Without that link, no reference would be achieved.

Direct reference theory is just the Referential Theory of Meaning applied to names. Descriptivism has been torn apart and we are back to a very interesting square one.

# Philosophy of Language — Week 11

Putnam, 'Meaning and Reference'

## 11.1 Semantic internalism vs semantic externalism

These are attitudes one could take towards meanings.

**Definition 11.1.**

(a) *Semantic internalism*: meanings are mental entities of some sort (thoughts, concepts).

(b) *Semantic externalism*: meanings are mind-external entities of some sort (functions, sets, etc.).

**Example 11.2.**

i. 'Dog' viewed with semantic internalism would be the concept DOG.

ii. 'Dog' viewed with semantic externalism would be the kind *canine*, or the function from possible worlds to the set of dogs.

Frege opposed semantic internalism because communication would not be effective without a common meaning of the word 'dog'. Semantic internalism is also known as *psychologism* (what Frege was opposing).

## 11.2 An argument for semantic internalism, and the Psychological Thesis

**Argument 11.3** (For semantic internalism)**.**

P1) Sentences express thoughts.

P2) Concepts are units, or constituents, of thoughts.

P3) Meaning is compositional.

C1) So, sentences couldn't express thoughts unless words expressed concepts.

C2) Hence, words express concepts.

**Definition 11.4** (Psychological Thesis)**.** Meanings are psychological states, like thoughts.

## 11.3 Semantic externalism and the Determination Thesis

(a) Functions relate each input to a unique output. Thus, identical functions with the same inputs must return identical outputs.

(b) For Frege, sense determines reference, so that the extension of an expression is a function of its sense.

**Definition 11.5** (Determination Thesis)**.** Meaning determines semantic value. That is, expressions having the same meaning must also have the same semantic value, though expressions can have the same semantic value without having the same meaning.

## 11.4 Singular, general, natural kind and artifact terms

**Definition 11.6.**

(a) *Singular terms*: expressions which refer (if at all) to one thing.

(b) *General terms*: expressions which refer (if at all) to multiple things of the same kind; common nouns are good examples.

(c) *Natural kind terms*: general terms referring to things which occur in nature and whose existence is not dependent on human nature.

(d) *Artifact terms*: general terms referring to artifacts, or human creations.

**Note.** General terms can effectively act as a good replacement for names. For the most part, these are natural kind terms:

1. We can existentially generalise over them (Water is on the floor $\Rightarrow$ something is on the floor).

2. They are not scope ambiguous (I didn't see water on the floor).

## 11.5 The Twin Earth experiment

The intention of this experiment is to show that meanings cannot be a function of anything psychological.

**Example 11.7** (Twin Earth)**.** Twin Earth is exactly like Earth at some point before the Scientific Revolution, and thus before the discovery of the chemical composition of water, say 1600. Earth and Twin Earth are exactly alike except in one respect: the stuff people on Earth call 'water' is composed of $H_2O$, while the stuff people on Twin Earth call 'water' is composed of something else, say XYZ. Despite this, people on Twin Earth have the exact same psychological states as people on Earth—they have the same beliefs, thoughts, concepts, etc. Yet 'water' on Twin Earth has a different semantic value than 'water' on Earth: on Earth, 'water' describes quantities of $H_2O$, while on Twin Earth it describes quantities of XYZ.

Assumptions:

1. Twin Earth is not a possible world, but another planet, which actually exists.

2. Putnam assumes that psychological states are physically determined, so that people who are molecule-for-molecule identical have the same psychological states. Thus, there can be no difference in psychological states without a corresponding difference in neurophysiology.

## 11.6 Putnam's argument against semantic internalism

**Argument 11.8** (Putnam)**.**

P1) Meaning determines semantic value.

C1) Thus, if the semantic value of an expression in one place is different from its semantic value in another, then that expression must be ambiguous.

P2) On Earth, the semantic value of 'water' is $H_2O$. On Twin Earth, the semantic value of 'water' is instead XYZ.

C2) P2) $\Rightarrow$ 'water' is ambiguous.

P3) The psychological states and concepts of English speakers on Earth are the same as those of English speakers on Twin Earth.

C3) Thus, speakers' psychological states or concepts do not determine semantic value.

C4) Thus, meanings cannot be psychological states or concepts.

## 11.7 The rigidity of natural kind terms

(a) Kripke proposed that natural kind terms, such as 'water', are rigid designators.

(b) Putnam further suggested that the meanings of natural kind terms have an indexical element to them.

(c) We can see the indexical in action in the following:

i. In all possible worlds, the semantic value of 'water' is whatever bears a similarity relation to what is water here, namely $H_2O$.

ii. We can use the similarity relation to create an equivalence class for water and $H_2O$.

## 11.8 Objections to Putnam

**Objection 11.9** (Indexicals)**.**

i. Putnam only shows that we must reject the *combination* of the Determination Thesis and the Psychological Thesis.

ii. David Kaplan's indexical theory. According to Kaplan, there are three aspects of meaning:

(a) *Character*: together with facts about context, determines content.

(b) *Content*: together with facts about the world, determines extension (Fregean sense).

(c) *Extension*: semantic value.

There is an aspect of meaning which does not determine semantic value, namely character. This threatens the Determination Thesis.

iii. The above implies that the Determination Thesis is false, and therefore meaning does not determine semantic value.

iv. In the argument against semantic internalism, we have falsified P1), which leaves us with P3) and C3):

P3) The psychological states and concepts of English speakers on Earth are the same as those of English speakers on Twin Earth.

C3) So, psychological states or concepts do not determine semantic value.

v. Even if C3) is true, the consequences of David Kaplan's theory still allow us to accept the Psychological Thesis:

(a) Meaning is not content, but character.

(b) Thus, meaning determines content, not semantic value.

(c) Character consists in speakers' psychological states or concepts.

vi. This implies that Twin Earth is consistent with semantic internalism.

**Objection 11.10** (Psychological externalism)**.**

**Definition 11.11** (Psychological externalism)**.** Psychological states and concepts are (at least partially) externally individuated. That is, the contents of beliefs and other psychological states, as well as the concepts which constitute them, are at least partially determined by one's physical environment.

This has the capacity to cripple P3) in Putnam's argument against semantic internalism. Psychological externalism implies that:

1. Suppose that while pointing at some $H_2O$, an Earth speaker forms the belief expressed by 'This is water'. And suppose the same thing happens for a Twin Earth speaker.
2. Given psychological externalism, these are different beliefs, as the concepts involved pick out different kinds of stuff: $H_2O$ and XYZ.
3. Thus, speakers on Earth and speakers on Twin Earth do not have the same psychological states, despite being molecular duplicates.

The above follows from these two theses:

(T1) Psychological states are individuated by their contents. Thus, psychological states having different contents are distinct.

(T2) Natural kind concepts are externally individuated. That is, the content of a concept like WATER is determined by one's physical environment.

By (T2), speakers on Earth possess different concepts than speakers on Twin Earth, because while $\text{WATER}_e$ picks out $H_2O$, $\text{WATER}_{te}$ picks out XYZ. So, by (T1), speakers' beliefs on Earth about water are different from those of speakers on Twin Earth. If so, then neurophysiology does not completely determine the contents of our psychological states.

# Philosophy of Language — Week 12

Kripke, 'A Puzzle about Belief'

Kripke decided to defend direct reference theory, considering he hated descriptivism. So he chose to defend it from arguments like the Strong Disquotation Argument.

## 12.1 The Strong Disquotation Argument against direct reference theory

**Definition 12.1** (Strong disquotation)**.** A normal speaker of language $L$ sincerely assents to a sentence $S$ in $L$ if and only if they believe what's expressed by $S$ in $L$.

**Argument 12.2** (The Strong Disquotation Argument against direct reference)**.**

(P1) It is possible to (rationally) assent to '$\alpha$ is $\alpha$' but not '$\alpha$ is $\beta$', where $\alpha = \beta$.

(C1) So, one can rationally believe that $\alpha$ is $\alpha$ but not that $\alpha$ is $\beta$, though $\alpha = \beta$.

(P2) If $A$ believes that $\alpha$ is $\alpha$ but not that $\alpha$ is $\beta$, then '$A$ believes that $\alpha$ is $\alpha$' is true while '$A$ believes that $\alpha$ is $\beta$' is false.

(C2) So, it is possible for '$A$ believes that $\alpha$ is $\alpha$' to be true while '$A$ believes that $\alpha$ is $\beta$' is false, even though $A$ is rational and $\alpha = \beta$.

(P3) If the meaning of a name were just its referent, then any two sentences differing only in the occurrence of a co-referential name would be synonymous.

(P4) Synonymous sentences cannot diverge in truth-values.

(C3) Hence, the meaning of a name cannot be just its referent.

## 12.2 Kripke's defence against the Strong Disquotation Argument

If we can reproduce the effect of the Substitution Argument using disquotation instead of substitutivity, then this suggests that the root of the problem is with disquotation. So, if disquotation is independently problematic, then the problem is not with DRT.

There are two further principles to rely on to reject Strong Disquotation:

**Definition 12.3.**

i. *Weak disquotation*: if a normal speaker of language $L$ sincerely assents to a sentence $S$ in $L$, then they believe what's expressed by $S$ in $L$.

ii. *Translation*: if a sentence $S$ in language $L$ expresses a truth in $L$, then any content-preserving translation of $S$ into $L'$ expresses a truth in $L'$.

**Note.** SD ⇒ WD; so rejecting WD is enough to reject Strong Disquotation.

The Pierre case combines both.

## 12.3 The Pierre case

**Example 12.4** (Setup)**.** Pierre grows up in France, speaking only French. Based on postcards and what he has heard, he assents to 'Londres est jolie'. Later, Pierre moves to an ugly part of London and learns to speak English by immersion, without ever leaving this part of the city. Based on his experience, he eventually assents to 'London is not pretty'. Despite this, he never recognizes that 'Londres' and 'London' are names for the same city. If asked, he would assent to both sentences while speaking English in London.

**Argument 12.5** (Pierre puzzle (the actual Frege puzzle))**.**

(P1) Pierre sincerely assents to 'Londres est jolie' and 'London is not pretty'.

(P2) 'Londres est jolie' translates as 'London is pretty' in English.

(C1) So, Pierre believes that London is pretty and that London is not pretty.

(P3) That London is pretty and London is not pretty is a contradiction.

(C2) Hence, Pierre has contradictory beliefs.

(P4) Having contradictory beliefs is irrational.

(P5) Being irrational requires some kind of mistake in reasoning.

(C3) Thus, Pierre has made a mistake in reasoning.

(P6) Pierre has made no mistake in reasoning, and his beliefs are perfectly rational.

1. This is a puzzle because at no point did Pierre actually make a mistake in his reasoning, relative to Pierre's perspective, which contradicts C3), C2) and C1).
2. From here, we reject both weak and strong disquotation, because despite sincerely assenting, Pierre did not believe what was expressed by the sentence he said.

## 12.4 The Paderewski case

The earlier argument might rely on the translation principle. Let's try something that relies only on weak disquotation.

**Example 12.6** (Paderewski's double life)**.** Peter is familiar with the famous Polish pianist Paderewski. Based on this, Peter assents to 'Paderewski has musical talent'. Later, Peter comes to learn about a Polish politician named 'Paderewski', and he is generally skeptical of the musical abilities of politicians. Based on this, he assents to 'Paderewski does not have musical talent'. However, Peter fails to realize that these are the same person.

i. By two applications of Weak Disquotation, Peter believes that Paderewski has musical talent and that Paderewski does not have musical talent.

ii. Although he may have a false belief about politicians, Peter has made no logical mistake. That is, while 'Paderewski is Paderewski' is a logical truth, Peter cannot infer a contradiction without realizing that both occurrences of 'Paderewski' refer to the same person, which is independent of logic.

## 12.5 The final argument against disquotation

**Argument 12.7.**

(P1) If Weak Disquotation were correct, then we would wrongly charge speakers with having irrational beliefs, despite their making no logical mistakes.

(P2) All else being equal, we ought to reject principles which require wrongly charging speakers with having irrational beliefs, despite their making no logical mistakes.

(C) So, we ought to reject Weak Disquotation.

## 12.6 Objections to the implications of Kripke's puzzles

**Objection 12.8** (Limited scope)**.** Even if the right conclusion to draw from Kripke's cases is that substitution failures involving 'believes' or 'thinks' are not problematic for DRT, these are not the only cases of substitution failure Frege originally considered. There are also cases involving 'knows', for instance, and also failure of substitution in direct quotation. Unless something similar can be said for these sorts of cases, this will not constitute a complete defence of Direct Reference Theory.

**Objection 12.9** (Rational contradictory beliefs)**.** There is a different way of responding to Kripke's cases which does not require rejecting disquotation. Suppose we accept disquotation and consider again (P4):

(P4) Having contradictory beliefs is irrational.

This may be false. Perhaps not all contradictory beliefs are irrational. In the cases of Pierre and Peter, their contradictory beliefs are not irrational because they do not assent to the identity statements 'Londres is London' and 'Paderewski$_1$ is Paderewski$_2$'. So we can accept that their beliefs are contradictory without charging them with irrationality.

# Philosophy of Language — Appendix A

Definitions or Concepts I May Have Missed

1. **Week 7.** *Exclusive disjunction*: an XOR gate. Exclusive "or"; it maps to the semantic value "false" if both disjuncts are true.
2. **Week 7.** *Inclusive disjunction*: inclusive "or"; it can have the same semantic value as a conjunction.
3. **Week 8.** *Epistemological holism* is the view that beliefs are not confirmed or disconfirmed by experience individually, but rather as an entire web, body, or tribunal.
4. **Week 7.** *Donnellan–Kripke debate*: whereas Frege and Strawson held that definite descriptions are singular terms, Russell instead maintained that they are quantificational expressions. In contrast, in his paper 'Reference and Definite Descriptions', Keith Donnellan argues that definite descriptions have both sorts of meanings, and so are ambiguous. However, in 'Speaker's Reference and Semantic Reference', Saul Kripke argues that definite descriptions have just one, Russellian meaning, with the appearance of reference explained as a kind of implicature. His argument appeals to GR: prefer a pragmatic explanation to a semantic one.

Citations

## Main source

The slides, and most of the content of these notes, are taken from the course *Introduction to Philosophy of Language* (PHI-2300/ENG-2910), taught by Professor Eric Snyder at Ashoka University in the Monsoon 2025 semester. This course is the main citation for these notes.

## Course textbooks

- Martinich, *The Philosophy of Language*, 3rd edition, 1996.
- Miller, *Philosophy of Language*, 2007.
- McGinn, *Philosophy of Language*, 2016.
- Lycan, *Philosophy of Language*, 2008.
- Soames, *Philosophy of Language*, 2010.

Another source of material is the MIT course on the Philosophy of Language: `https://ocw.mit.edu/courses/24-251-introduction-to-philosophy-of-language-fall-2011/`

## Readings by week

Supplemental, non-required readings are marked with an asterisk (∗).

**Week 1: Preliminaries**

- Syllabus
- 'Introduction', pp. 3–19
- ∗ pp. xvii–xviii
- ∗ pp. 1–6
- ∗ `https://iep.utm.edu/lang-phi/#H5`

**Week 2: Frege: Reference and Compositionality**

- Gottlob Frege, 'On Sense and Nominatum', pp. 186–189
- 'Frege: Semantic Value and Reference', pp. 1–21
- ∗ pp. 1–6
- ∗ pp. 1–17
- ∗ pp. 7–13

* https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/reference/
* https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/compositionality/

**Week 3: Frege: Sense and Substitutivity**

– 'Frege and Russell: Sense and Definite Descriptions', pp. 23–36, 43–52

– 'Frege on Sense and Reference', pp. 1–24

* pp. 31–37
* pp. 13–20
* https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/frege/

**Week 4: Russell's Theory of Descriptions**

– Bertrand Russell, 'Descriptions', pp. 208–213

– 'Russell on Definite Descriptions', pp. 55–72

* pp. 64–69
* pp. 9–18
* pp. 20–26
* https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/descriptions/

**Week 5: The Description Theory of Names**

– 'Proper Names: the Description Theory', pp. 31–43

– 'Frege and Russell: Sense and Definite Descriptions', pp. 64–77

* pp. 26–32
* Stephen Neale (1993), *Descriptions*
* https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/descriptions/
* https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/reference/

**Week 6: Strawson on Referring**

– P.F. Strawson, 'On Referring', pp. 215–224

– 'Definite Descriptions', pp. 19–23

* pp. 77–78
* pp. 80–83
* Bertrand Russell, 'Mr. Strawson on Referring'
* https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/descriptions/

**Week 7: Grice's Theory of Implicature**

- Paul Grice, 'Logic and Conversation', pp. 156–163
- 'Implicative Relations', pp. 86–96
  * pp. 246–253, 259–264
  * pp. 191–202
  * `https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/grice/`
  * `https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/implicature/`

**Week 8: Verificationism and Quine's Skepticism**

- W.V.O. Quine, 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism', Intro and Sections 1, 5 and 6
- 'Skepticism about Sense (I)', pp. 126–140
  * pp. 98–107
  * `https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/quine/`, §3
  * `https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/logical-empiricism/#EmpVerAntMet`, §4.1–2

**Week 9: Tarski and Davidson**

- Alfred Tarski, 'The Semantic Conception of Truth', §§1–12 (pp. 61–70)
- 'Sense and Truth: Tarski and Davidson', pp. 271–305 (section 8.5 is optional)
  * pp. 165–190
  * pp. 109–124
  * pp. 33–48
  * `https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/tarski-truth/`
  * `https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/davidson/`, §3

**Week 10: Possible Worlds and Direct Reference**

- Saul Kripke, 'Naming and Necessity', pp. 259–266
- 'Kripke on Names', pp. 35–49
  * pp. 45–58
  * pp. 77–92
  * Saul Kripke (1980), *Naming and Necessity*
  * `https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/rigid-designators/`
  * `https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/logic-modal-origins/`, §3.2

**Week 11: Twin Earth and Semantic Externalism**

- Hilary Putnam, 'Meaning and Reference', pp. 284–288
- 'Putnam on Semantic Externalism', pp. 133–146
  * pp. 58–60

* pp. 323–329
* pp. 88–91
* https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/natural-kinds/, §4
* https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/skepticism-content-externalism/, §3

**Week 12: Kripke's Puzzle**

– Saul Kripke, 'A Puzzle About Belief', pp. 392–395, 398–401

– 'Kripke's Puzzle About Belief', pp. 203–209

* https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/prop-attitude-reports/